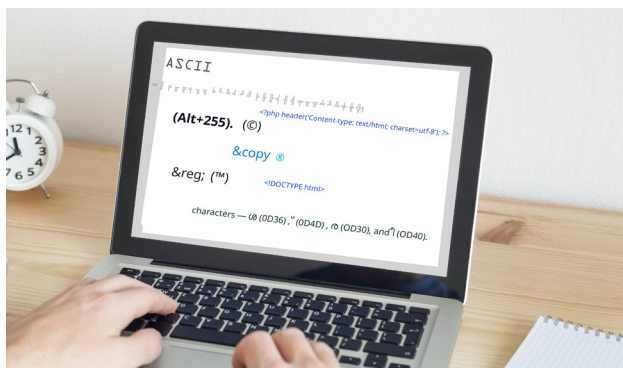


Try These Unusual Unicode Tricks

Much thought from the finest brains all over the world has gone into the making of Unicode. Its main purpose is to serve all mankind. If you are a developer, do not make the mistake of ignoring this encoding standard.



Some things that nobody teaches us are learnt the hard way. Did your computer course teach you to acquire resources as late as possible and release them early? Did any programming book tell you that software should not be developed using Visual Studio while it is running with administrator privileges? Every developer goes through the process of learning new and best-practices while unlearning old and die-hard ones. If you haven't read the article titled, *The Absolute Minimum Every Software Developer Absolutely, Positively Must Know About Unicode and Character Sets (No Excuses!)* written in 2003 by Joel Spolsky (co-founder of *StackOverflow.com*), I suggest you read it before writing another line of code.

Unicode

Unicode is a unified text scheme for representing characters of over 150 languages, the list of which also includes Braille, sign language, Esperanto, musical notations, hieroglyphs, cuneiform, chemical symbols, emoticons and dingbats. Microsoft had a big font named *Arial Unicode MS* that was supposed to support all of Unicode. However, the tech giant gave that up, once Unicode continued to grow.

When learning programming for the first time with a language such as C, it is easy to assume that a character is the same as a byte or that a byte comprises only 8-bits. If your computer course rushed through such details, please run through and spend some time on the basics from a proper C

language book. Spolsky's article mentions how the creators of PHP initially wrote the Web scripting language without support for Unicode!

ASCII

Unicode represents a paradigm shift from the days when boxes were drawn in the headers of C code using characters in the extended ASCII set (128 extra codes added to the 128-code ASCII). It is better than traditional ASCII art even today.

In Unicode, the box-drawing characters (┌ ┐ └ ┘ ┆ ┇ ┈ ┉ ┊ ┋ ┌ ┐ └ ┘ ┆ ┇ ┈ ┉ ┊ ┋) were moved further up into the stratosphere.

In the early days of computing, I worked primarily on DOS. Windows was a GUI program that ran on it. On a DOS keyboard, you could type the copyright symbol (©) by holding down the *Alt* key and typing *0169* on the numeric keypad. On lab computers that did not have floppy drives, I created undeletable directories in the hard disk by suffixing the directory names with an undetectable space symbol (*Alt+255*). A more subversive trick was to use memory utilities and change the name of a directory to 'CON' in the file allocation table (FAT). Windows, too, would not allow you to touch a file or directory named CON because it was a reserved file descriptor for the console in DOS. For many years, Linux would let you create a directory named CON in a Windows partition if you wanted to. But that was fixed later.

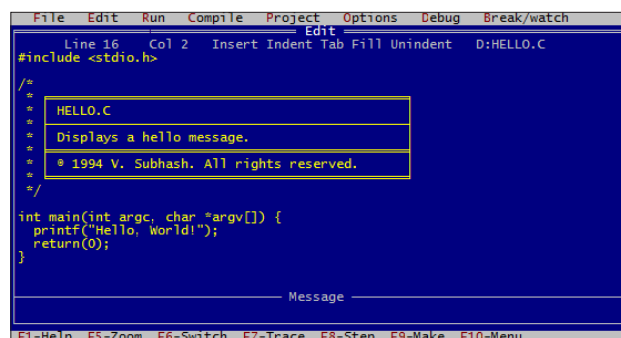


Figure 1: The uber way of beautifying comments in source code